

AUTHORITY PROPAGATION FRAMEWORK

HOW AUTHORITY MOVES THROUGH AUTONOMOUS SYSTEMS—AND WHAT MUST REMAIN TRUE AS IT PROPAGATES.

REV 02.0

JULY 26, 2026

AOI FRAMEWORK SERIES

FRAMEWORK PURPOSE: Authority rarely remains with the originating principal. Autonomous systems may delegate work across agents, services, tools, and business systems. This framework illustrates how conferred authority propagates through an execution chain, how its scope must remain bounded, and what Runtime Governance must be able to evaluate when execution occurs.

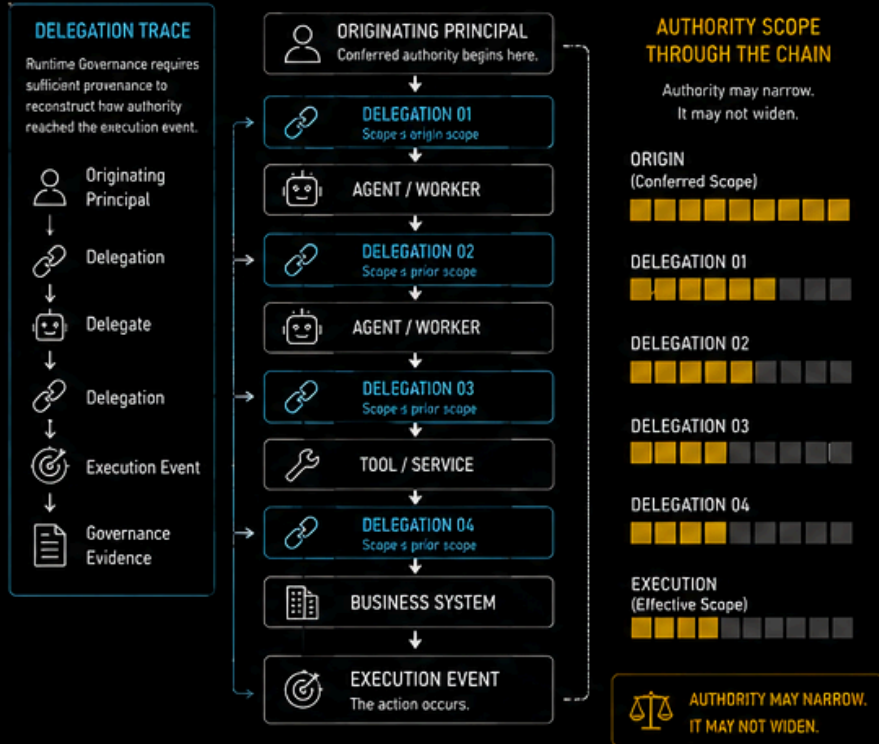
EXECUTION CHAINS MAY INCLUDE

- Human actors
- AI agents
- Automated services
- APIs
- Enterprise systems

DELEGATION MUST PRESERVE

- Authority boundaries**
What authority may be conveyed?
- Scope**
What actions and targets remain permitted?
- Context**
What conditions constrain its exercise?
- Provenance**
Where did the authority originate?
- Intent reference**
What objective initiated the execution chain?

HOW AUTHORITY PROPAGATES



EVERY DELEGATION CREATES GOVERNANCE QUESTIONS

- WHO IS ACTING?**
Identify the principal, agent, service, or system exercising authority.
- WHAT AUTHORITY WAS CONFERRED?**
Identify the authority conveyed to this delegate and its boundaries.
- DID THE AUTHORITY WIDEN?**
Verify that delegated authority remains within the scope conveyed by the preceding hop.
- CAN THE CHAIN BE RECONSTRUCTED?**
Establish sufficient provenance to trace the execution to authority actually conferred.

Propagation establishes how authority reached the execution. Runtime Governance evaluates whether the resulting execution is legitimate.

RELATED RUNTIME GOVERNANCE CONCEPTS

DELEGATION CHAIN
The ordered sequence through which authority is conveyed.

AUTHORITY PROVENANCE
Whether execution traces through an unbroken chain to authority actually conferred.

EXECUTION EVENT
The composite object (Principal, Delegation, Action, Target, Context, Intent, Provenance) evaluated by Runtime Governance.

INTENT
The originating objective against which execution may be evaluated for conformance.

GOVERNANCE EVIDENCE
The reasoning and inputs supporting legitimacy, including the delegation chain and signal freshness.

GOVERNANCE LAW

AUTHORITY MAY NARROW. IT MAY NOT WIDEN.

As authority propagates, its origin, scope, and delegation path must remain reconstructable.

If authority provenance cannot be established, Execution Legitimacy cannot be established.